

Tobias Treppmann

Design leader who still designs — a team, a design system across surfaces, and hands on the work every week

CONTACT

LOCATION

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EDUCATION

M.A. Leadership

Kairos University, South Dakota, USA
2022 – 2026

Theological Studies

Theologisches Seminar Rheinland
2003 – 2007

LANGUAGES

German · native

English · C2, fluent

ONGOING

Independent Consultant

Oratio&Co

2016 – Present · Remote

Collaborative leadership coaching and product-strategy consulting for mission-driven organizations.

PROFILE

I lead design functions and I stay in the craft. Fifteen years in B2B software, most of it vertical products for people who did not choose to be software users: analysts inside banks, parish offices, funeral directors. I have run a team of five, held product management and all of product design at the same time, and built a design system that ships as an API rather than a Figma file. The last year went into AI that runs in production rather than AI that demos.

EXPERIENCE

Head of Product Design

2025 – Present

Bibel TV (broadcaster in linear-to-streaming transformation — iOS, Android, web, connected TV; engineering is an external agency) · Hamburg + Berlin, Germany

- Prototypes in real code, and the agency ships from them — web first, then Android, running against real APIs rather than clickable mockups. engineering ships from that code. The handoff crosses a company boundary and still holds.
- I write the specs and run the board — the tickets engineering works from are mine to write and prioritize, and I check the built feature in production and beta rather than calling it done at handoff.
- AI support copilot, live in production — assistive drafting for viewer letters in the handbook's wording. An explicit restricted-topic list sits in the system prompt, the draft is suppressed when the input is not a viewer enquiry, and every send decision stays human. Operated manually, and adoption was optional.
- AI fundraising ecosystem, built solo end to end — analysis, prompt architecture, prototype, then a production Claude skill generating follow-up content across in-app, web and video.
- Design system as an API — DTCG tokens, Style Dictionary, multi-platform sync. Built without a platform team, so that consistency holds structurally instead of by asking people.

Head of Platform and Design

2024 – 2025

ChurchDesk (vertical ERP for churches and dioceses — ~50 people, DE / DK / UK / SE / NO / CH) · Copenhagen, Denmark · Remote from Berlin

- Designer and product manager at once — product management for the main platform plus all product design. I wrote the specs, ran the ticket board engineering worked from, and was the main customer-facing contact for the launch parish throughout.
- Booking module — the decision I defended through the build — inherited a €20k client-funded project scoped as a standalone add-on and reframed it into a platform capability, holding that line to delivery. 70% coordination-time reduction and 90% acceptance at the launch customer. It then shipped to every customer as general booking.
- The design bar was mine to set — senior-most designer on the platform, with a designer on the team working to it.
- AI alt-text in production — shipped for EU accessibility compliance under GDPR plus Protestant and Catholic church data-protection law, across six countries.
- Two engineers, two months, daily contact — design in Figma, build in code, and I was in the build every day rather than at the end of it.

Head of Product Design

2023 – 2024

Ninox Software GmbH (no-code business platform — DACH / UK / US) · Berlin, Germany

- Prompt-to-database onboarding, with the CEO and technical co-founder (freelance, summer 2025) — the AI-generated schema renders into the real data-model editor, not a chat preview, so people can see and correct what the model produced. It became the basis for the public AI beta.
- Research at a scale a team cannot read — Claude over thousands of forum posts for sentiment, pain points and feature requests, with Dovetail as the shared repository. Above a few hundred data points that analysis happens or it does not happen at all; below it, I read the responses.
- Senior Leadership Team, 5 direct reports including a design lead — and shared design-system governance established across 4 designers and engineering.

Product & UX Strategist

2021 – 2022

Hypoport hub SE (shared services arm of listed Hypoport SE) · Berlin / Lübeck, Germany · Remote

- Service-to-product transformation — partnered with the executive team to productize the service organization. Case-by-case support became a standard catalog.
- Methodology transfer — ran design-thinking training for executive leadership and service teams.

Director of Design

2016 – 2021

Datameer GmbH (collaborative data analytics for top US / CA / UK banks and insurers) · Berlin, Germany · team across Germany and NYC

- Five years of data-dense B2B desktop interfaces — big-data pivot tables, column charts, aggregated JSON views, result cards and filter logic. The hardest of them was the query-builder preview, where the result you see is a sample and the interface has to be honest about that without becoming unreadable.

- Research inside institutions that make users hard to reach — pioneered iterative [usertesting.com](#) screening to get to analysts working inside banks and insurers. The platform operated under HIPAA compliance among other frameworks.
- Led the design team across Germany and NYC for five years — two UX designers reporting to me. A six-hour gap, held together by cross-timezone collaboration processes I established.
- Design system — I defined component behavior and specs across the library, and the UI designers executed the visual system.

EARLIER CAREER PROGRESSION

UX Strategy Lead · *Spreadshirt* · 2014 – 2016 · Leipzig, Germany

UX Manager · *HairDirect* · 2013 – 2014 · Lancaster, PA, USA

User Experience Designer · *andCulture* · 2012 – 2013 · Harrisburg, PA, USA

Web Designer & Front-End Developer · *HOPE International* · 2009 – 2012 · Lancaster, PA, USA

Web Designer · *Bajaa.com* · 2008 – 2009 · Düsseldorf, Germany

Freelance Web Designer · 2003 – 2008 · Düsseldorf, Germany

Web Designer · *Bajaa.com* · 2000 – 2003 · Düsseldorf, Germany

E-Commerce Assistant · *Westfalia Werkzeugcompany* · 1999 · Hagen, Germany

SKILLS

Design Leadership

Team of five including a design lead at Ninox, on the Senior Leadership Team · Hired two, promoted two, and made the call when someone was not the right fit · Interim Head of Product for four months · Coached a design lead through a strained engineering relationship rather than around it · Design-thinking training for executive leadership and service teams at Hypoport

Product Ownership, Not Only Aesthetics

Held product management for the main platform alongside all product design at ChurchDesk · Wrote the specs and ran the ticket board engineering worked from · Interim Head of Product at Ninox · Owned the build-versus-buy and standalone-versus-embedded decisions and held the second one through delivery · 70% coordination-time reduction and 90% booking acceptance at the launch customer

Design Systems Across Surfaces

Design system as an API at Bibel TV: DTCG tokens in three tiers from global primitives through semantic to component, built with Style Dictionary, synced live to Figma and Android with iOS and web ready · One commit propagates to every platform · Co-built the Datameer system, where UX defined component behavior and specs and UI executed the visual system · Governance run as a cross-functional working group with assigned members and an escalation path

Brand as a System

Built Bibel TV's color engine: a custom color-extraction API and config tool, live in production, deriving image-based card gradients perceptually from content artwork with k-means and OKLCH, holding WCAG contrast in both light and dark · The machinery that makes a visual language hold across content nobody has seen yet · Selah — Mindful Transitions: a macOS app designed, built and shipped solo on the Mac App Store, including the product, the interface, the icon and the store listing

Hands-On Craft

Prototypes built in real code against real production APIs, web first then Android · Iteration moved from days of spec-and-handoff to hours in working code · Engineering at Bibel TV is an external agency, so that handoff crosses a company boundary and holds anyway · Complex systems simplified into usable interfaces: the query-builder preview shows a sample, and the interface has to say so without becoming unreadable

AI-First Practice

Claude Code, Claude Projects and Claude skills as daily tools, plus Cursor and Zed · A support copilot live in production for viewer services · An AI fundraising ecosystem built solo end to end, from analysis through prompt architecture and prototype to a production skill · AI alt-text generation shipped for EU accessibility compliance · "Designing with and for AI" workshop series run since 2024 with a partner agency

Customers Who Are Not Software People

Funeral directors, parish assistants and priests at ChurchDesk, three stakeholder groups with opposing needs on one surface · Recurring validation calls with the launch customer's project lead throughout delivery · Analysts inside top US, Canadian and UK banks and insurers at Datameer · Research access into regulated enterprises that had never granted it · Regular customer interviews run himself — funeral directors, parish assistants and priests, three groups with opposing needs on one surface, turned into product decisions